

The Influence of Culture and Religion

by Sophia



WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn about the way ethics varies from place to place, even within the same country but especially internationally; these differences are often due to religious differences.

Specifically, this lesson will cover:

1. Cultural Dimensions

1a. Individualism vs. Collectivism

1b. Long-Term Orientation vs. Short-Term Orientation

1c. Masculinity vs. Femininity

1d. Uncertainty Avoidance

1e. Indulgence vs. Restraint

1f. Power Distance Index

2. Religion

3. Ethnocentrism

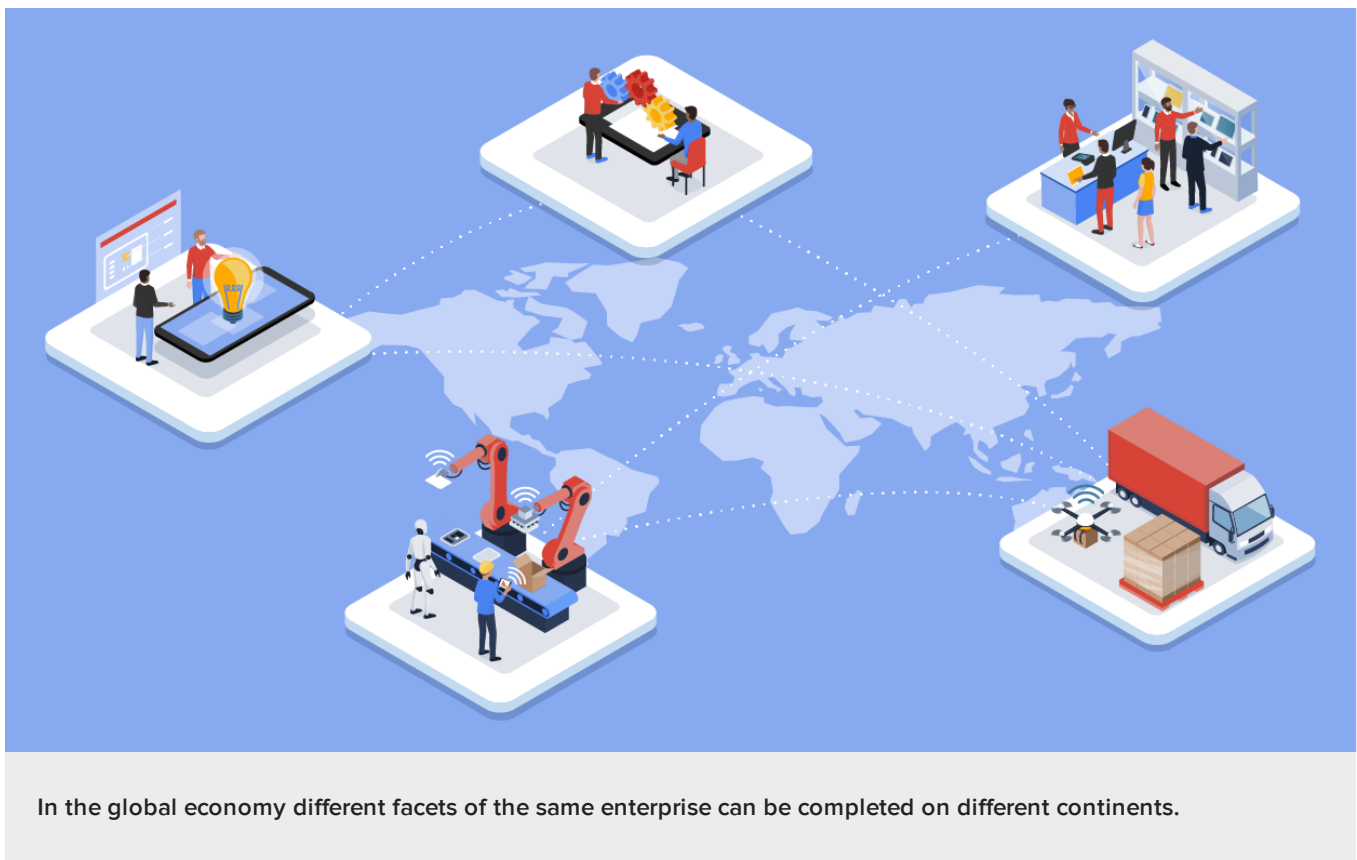
1. Cultural Dimensions



WATCH

How can understanding cultural dimensions help in developing good working relationships?

Many of us now have jobs with international connections. These global relationships teach us to be sensitive not just to other languages and customs but also to other people's worldviews. A company looking to move its production to another country may be interested in setting up supply, distribution, and value chains that support human rights, worker safety, and equity for women and the LGBTQ+ community, while the local culture is excited about the economic benefits it will gain from the company's presence: employment, taxes, and improved infrastructure. These goals need not be in conflict, but they must be integrated if the company is to reach an ethically sound agreement with the host country. Dialogue and openness are crucial to this process, just as they are in every other kind of relationship.



Geography affects a business’s relationship with almost any type of stakeholder, from stockholders and employees to customers, the government, and the environment—hence, the growing importance of **localization**, the process of adapting a product for non-native environments and languages, especially other nations and cultures. Such adaptation often starts with language translation but may include customizing content or products to the tastes and consumption habits of the local market; converting currencies, dates, and other measurements to regional standards; and addressing community regulations and legal requirements.

Research has shown that successful leaders and organizations with global responsibilities “need to understand and exceed the leadership expectations in the cultures they are interacting with.” In its study of leadership effectiveness and organizational behavior across cultures, the GLOBE leadership project of the Beedie School of Business at Simon Fraser University found leader effectiveness is contextual and strongly connected to cultural and organizational values. The study also concluded that, although leaders learn to adapt to cultural expectations, they often have to exceed those expectations to be truly successful. In other words, business has a role beyond merely reflecting the culture in which it operates. Developing the cultural competence to understand and adapt to other cultures is thus crucial to business success in the 21st century.

The Dutch researcher Geert Hofstede (1928–2020) identified six dimensions to help describe and understand differences in culture.

1a. Individualism vs. Collectivism

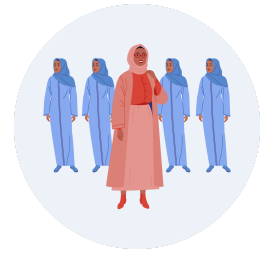
In individualistic cultures like the United States, people perceive themselves as empowered individuals, capable of making their own decisions and able to make an impact on their own lives. Collectivist cultures, however, focus on familial or community relationships over individual needs. Cultural viewpoint is not an

either/or perspective, but rather a continuum or range. You may belong to some communities that express individualistic cultural values, while others place the focus on a collective viewpoint. Collectivist cultures, including many in Asia and South America, focus on the needs of the nation, community, family, or group of workers.



THINK ABOUT IT

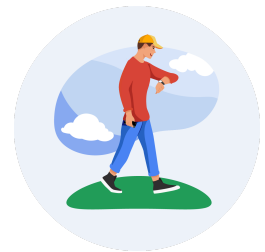
How does someone raised in a culture that emphasizes the community interact with someone raised in a primarily individualistic culture? How could tensions be expressed, and how might interactions be influenced by this point of divergence? How is time a relevant factor across cultures?



1b. Long-Term Orientation vs. Short-Term Orientation

Many countries value a long-term orientation, whereas other countries have a more short-term approach to life and results.

In some countries, particularly the West, waiting in line can make people impatient, and some try to utilize the time by making calls or tending to business while they wait. In other countries, such as some countries in Africa, the wait is taken more casually, with people striking up conversations and in no great hurry; they don't worry about "wasting" time. Similarly, business relationships that develop quickly in the West—perhaps over a game of golf or a "power lunch"—may take years to develop in countries like China, where networking may take a lifetime or even generations.



If you work within a culture that has a short-term orientation, you may need to place greater emphasis on reciprocation of greeting in a prompt manner, such as sending thank-you notes to hosts after a business meeting. Personal reliability and consistency are also valued in a short-term oriented culture, contributing to an overall sense of predictability and familiarity.

Long-term orientation is often marked by persistence, thrift and frugality, and an order to relationships based on age and status. A sense of honor or shame for the family and community is also observed across generations. What an individual does reflects on the family and is carried by immediate and extended family members.

1c. Masculinity vs. Femininity

Hofstede describes the masculine/feminine dichotomy not in terms of whether men or women hold the power in a given culture but rather in terms of the extent to which that culture values certain traits that are typically considered masculine (assertiveness, ambition) or feminine (caring, nurturing). The women in feminine countries have the same modest, caring values as the men; in the masculine countries, they are somewhat assertive and competitive, but not as much as the men, so that these countries still show a gap between men's values and women's values.



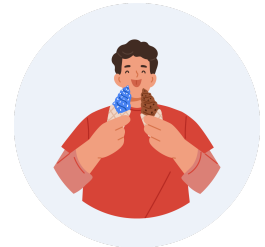
1d. Uncertainty Avoidance

Another way cultures can vary widely is tolerance for change and ambiguity. A society that has a high avoidance of uncertainty will be more dedicated to tradition, and less receptive to people who do not follow the rules of behavior. Societies that do not avoid uncertainty may not only be more receptive to differences, but celebrate them. As you might observe, there can be a gap in uncertainty avoidance within a national culture.



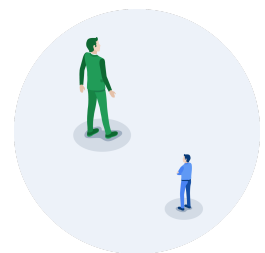
1e. Indulgence vs. Restraint

Dress is one of many ways that cultures vary in indulgence, or gratification, particularly in public. In the U.S., such indulgence that displays wealth, or **conspicuous consumption**, is generally accepted. Historically, Asian countries are more restrained, though the cultures with thriving business cultures like Japan and South Korea are rapidly changing.



1f. Power Distance Index

Finally, how comfortable are you with critiquing your boss's decisions? If you are from a low power distance culture, your answer might be, "No problem." In low power distance cultures, people relate to one another more as equals and less as a reflection of dominant or subordinate roles, regardless of their actual formal roles as employee and manager, for example.



If you are working with people from a high power distance culture, you may need to take extra care to elicit feedback and involve them in the discussion, because their cultural framework may preclude their participation. They may have learned that less powerful people must accept decisions without comment, even if they have a concern or know there is a significant problem. Unless you are sensitive to cultural orientation and power distance, you may lose valuable information.



REFLECT

You have examined points of similarity and difference across cultures. All cultures may engage in social and status competitions, but how they do it is quite different. From views on time to the importance of the individual or what it means to be masculine or feminine, cultural expectations are diverse and distinct. Learning to recognize cultural values in actions and behaviors allows you to gain some insight into other cultures.



TERMS TO KNOW

Localization

The process of adapting a product for non-native environments and languages, especially other nations and cultures.

Conspicuous Consumption

The flagrant display of wealth.

2. Religion

Another major difference between people that affects culture and ethics is religion. For example, the current debate over the redistribution of goods and services has Christian roots, and the Industrial Revolution in England and northern Europe looked to Protestant Christianity for the values of frugality, hard work, industriousness, and simplicity. Until the seventeenth century, religion and ethics were nearly inseparable. Many believed that people could not be persuaded to do the right thing without the threat of eternal damnation. The Enlightenment attempted to peel religion away from ethics, but even Kant acknowledged the need to base morality on something beyond the rationalism of his time.

Religions are neither uniform nor monolithic, nor are they unchanging over time. The core of Christianity, for instance, does not change, but its emphasis in any given period does. Moreover, the state or crown often worked side by side with the church in the past, choosing certain teachings over others to promote its own interests. This cooperation was evident during the era of mercantilism when the issue of personhood, or the inherent freedom and capacity to make decisions and act morally, was hotly debated in the context of slavery. Although the church officially opposed slavery, the conquest of new lands was justified theologically as bringing salvation and civilization to populations considered savage and unsophisticated. Christianity was thought to save them from their pagan ways just as Islam and the message of the prophet saved unbelievers in the East. Behavioral norms for the clergy were founded and supported by the divine right of kings and the authority of religious tradition. Commerce and trade followed these norms.

By the time of the Industrial Revolution and postindustrial eras, Protestantism and its values of frugality, hard work, and simplicity (the “Protestant ethic”) had helped create a culture of individualism and entrepreneurship in the West, particularly in Great Britain and the United States. In fact, the Protestant work ethic, religion, and a commitment to hard work all are intertwined in the business history of both these countries.

IN CONTEXT

One example of the fusion of religion and business is John D. Rockefeller, who, in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, commanded the attention given today to Bill Gates and Elon Musk as an emblem of success.

No one was more convinced of the link between religious faith and success in business than Rockefeller, who clung to his Baptist faith from his early years until his death in 1937. The richest person of his age, Rockefeller earned his fortune as the founder and major shareholder of Standard Oil but always regarded his billions as a public trust rather than his personal prize.

Despite criticism, even from family members, Rockefeller donated enormous sums to many causes, especially medical research and higher education. He financed the founding of the University of Chicago as an institution that would train students to pursue their professional and business interests under the guidance of Christian faith. Later in life, and as his philanthropic motivation increased, his endowment of several charitable causes more fully reflected his belief as to how God wished him to dispose of a sizable portion of his wealth.

Of course, Rockefeller’s concept of stewardship—an attitude toward money and capital that stresses

care and responsibility rather than pure utility—can be found across cultures and religions in various forms, and there are many similarities among the Judaic, Islamic, and Christian views of money and its use toward a greater end.

Although religious practices and cultural assumptions remain strongly in place, fewer people in the West today profess a religion than in the past. Yet this does not mean there is a decline in ethos. In fact, consumers increasingly consider how something was made, who made it, and environmental impact in their purchasing decisions. From coffee to clothing, purchasers are voting with their money. Because of this, businesses must consider the **3P model** (also called the **triple bottom line**)—people, planet, and profit—when defining their own business success.

Does this development affect the way you approach business relationships and conduct negotiations? Might you see a universal, secular code of ethics developing in place of religion? If so, how would it accommodate the differences across time, regions, and cultures discussed in this tutorial? Ethical businesses will have to balance all these factors when adopting standards of conduct and local practices.



TERM TO KNOW

3P Model (or Triple Bottom Line)

Defining business success not just by profit but by profits and the impact on people and the planet.

3. Ethnocentrism

Culture is part of the very fabric of thought, and people cannot separate themselves from it, even as they leave home, defining themselves anew in work and achievements. Every business or organization has a culture, and within what may be considered a global culture, there are many subcultures or co-cultures. For example, consider the difference between the sales and accounting departments in a corporation. You will likely see two distinct groups with their own symbols, vocabulary, and values. Within each group, there may also be smaller groups, and each member of each department comes from a distinct background that in itself influences behavior and interaction.

Ethnocentrism is the tendency to view other cultures as inferior to one's own. Having pride in your culture can be healthy, but history has taught us that having a predisposition to discount other cultures simply because they are different can be hurtful, damaging, and dangerous. Ethnocentrism makes us far less likely to be able to bridge the gap with others and often increases intolerance of difference. Business and industry are no longer regional, and in your career, you will necessarily cross borders, languages, and cultures. You will need tolerance, understanding, patience, and openness to difference. A skilled business communicator knows that the process of learning is never complete, and being open to new ideas is a key strategy for success.

All of this speaks to the awareness and cultural sensitivity that must be exhibited by an ethical manager doing business in a region different from his or her own. Certain mistakes, particularly accidental ones and those not motivated by malicious design, will likely be forgiven. Still, a global ethical demeanor requires that you be as conscious as possible as to what constitutes courtesy wherever you find yourself conducting business.



TERM TO KNOW

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The tendency to view other cultures as inferior to one's own.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned about the cultural variations in ethics. Modern businesses are usually multinational in scope, meaning that the ability to navigate global relationships is essential. Being aware of **cultural dimensions** can help one understand and work across cultures; for example, Western culture stresses **individualism over collectivism**, values traditionally **masculine** traits over **feminine** traits (though less than some countries), has a **short-term orientation rather than long-term**, has a high tolerance for **uncertainty**, tends to prize **indulgence** over restraint, and has a low **power distance index** compared to other countries. **Religion** tends to inform the ethical values of different countries; however, remember that religion is not the same for all practitioners or unchanging over time. Although business culture is increasingly secular, it is a mistake to presume it is less ethical; in fact, there is more emphasis on people and the planet along with profits—the “3P model” or “triple bottom line.” In learning about these cultures, it is important to abstain from **ethnocentrism**, or the assumption that your own culture is superior.

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